

OVERVIEW:

Business development is a core commercial function focused on driving revenue growth through new market entry, strategic partnerships, and expansion opportunities. In Malaysia, this function exists across all sectors, including startups, SMEs, and multinational corporations, making it a highly versatile career path. Business development professionals identify opportunities, build relationships, and create strategies that help organisations grow beyond their current capabilities. In startups, the role often overlaps with sales and strategy, while in larger organisations it can be more specialised and structured. As Malaysia's economy becomes more connected regionally, business development roles increasingly involve cross-border partnerships and regional expansion.

WORK ENVIRONMENT:

The work environment in business development is typically client-facing and target-driven, with a strong emphasis on building and maintaining relationships. Many roles involve frequent meetings, networking events, and sometimes travel, especially when dealing with regional or international markets. In startups, business development professionals often work in fast-paced environments where they handle multiple responsibilities, from pitching to closing deals. In larger corporations, the role may be more defined, with clear processes, support teams, and longer sales cycles. The job requires a balance between strategic thinking, such as identifying growth opportunities, and execution, such as negotiating deals and following up with clients.

WHO THRIVES HERE:

Individuals who thrive in business development are typically persuasive and confident communicators who enjoy influencing others. Strategic thinking is important, as they must identify opportunities and position their organisation effectively in competitive markets. Strong networking ability helps in building long-term relationships that lead to business opportunities. Resilience is essential, as rejection and slow deal cycles are common in this field. An entrepreneurial mindset is also valuable, as business development often involves creating opportunities from scratch and thinking creatively about growth.

CORE SKILL DOMAINS:

Market research and opportunity identification are essential skills in business development, as professionals must understand industry trends, customer needs, and competitive landscapes. This involves analysing data, identifying gaps in the market, and evaluating potential opportunities for growth. Strong research skills enable better decision-making and increase the chances of successful deals.

Proposal writing is a critical skill, as business development professionals often need to present structured and persuasive business cases to clients or partners. This includes outlining value propositions, pricing, timelines, and expected outcomes in a clear and compelling manner. Well-written proposals can significantly influence decision-making and secure new business.

Negotiation skills are central to closing deals and forming partnerships. Professionals must balance achieving favourable terms for their organisation while maintaining positive

relationships with clients or partners. This requires confidence, preparation, and the ability to handle objections effectively.

CRM and pipeline management are important for tracking leads, managing relationships, and ensuring consistent follow-up. Business development professionals use CRM systems to organise contacts, monitor deal progress, and forecast revenue. Strong pipeline management helps maintain a steady flow of opportunities and reduces the risk of missed deals.

Financial modelling for deals is necessary for evaluating the commercial viability of opportunities. This includes analysing costs, revenue projections, and return on investment. Understanding financial implications allows professionals to make informed recommendations and structure deals that benefit both parties.

Stakeholder presentation skills are important for communicating ideas and proposals to internal and external audiences. Professionals must be able to present complex information clearly and confidently, whether to clients, senior management, or partners. Strong presentation skills can influence decisions and build credibility.

JOB FAMILIES AND ROLES:

A Business Development Executive is typically an entry-level role focused on identifying leads and supporting deal-making activities. Day-to-day work includes researching potential clients, reaching out through calls or emails, and assisting in preparing proposals. Responsibilities involve building a pipeline of opportunities and supporting senior team members in closing deals. Must-have skills include communication and persistence, while familiarity with CRM tools is a good-to-have. This role suits individuals who are proactive and eager to learn. Entry usually requires a diploma or degree, with growth into senior BD or account management roles.

A Partnership Manager focuses on building and maintaining strategic relationships with external partners. Daily tasks include coordinating joint initiatives, managing partner expectations, and identifying opportunities for collaboration. Responsibilities involve ensuring partnerships deliver value and align with business goals. Must-have skills include relationship management and negotiation, while industry knowledge is beneficial. This role suits individuals who enjoy long-term relationship building. Entry typically requires experience in business development or account management, with progression into senior partnership or strategic roles.

A Sales Strategist works on designing and improving sales and growth strategies within an organisation. Day-to-day work includes analysing sales data, identifying performance gaps, and developing plans to improve results. Responsibilities focus on aligning sales efforts with broader business objectives. Must-have skills include analytical thinking and strategic planning, while experience with data tools is advantageous. This role suits individuals who prefer planning and optimisation over direct selling. Entry often requires experience in sales or business analysis, with growth into senior strategy or leadership roles.

A Market Expansion Manager is responsible for entering new markets, whether geographically or through new customer segments. Daily work includes conducting market research, assessing

risks, and developing entry strategies. Responsibilities involve coordinating cross-functional teams and ensuring successful market entry. Must-have skills include strategic thinking and project management, while cultural awareness and international experience are valuable. This role suits individuals who enjoy exploring new opportunities and working on complex projects. Entry typically requires several years of experience, with progression into regional leadership roles.

A BD Director leads the overall business development strategy for an organisation. Day-to-day work includes setting growth targets, overseeing teams, and managing high-level partnerships. Responsibilities involve driving revenue growth, aligning BD efforts with company strategy, and reporting to senior leadership. Must-have skills include leadership, strategic vision, and strong negotiation ability, while industry expertise is highly beneficial. This role suits experienced professionals with a proven track record in deal-making. Entry requires significant experience, with progression into executive leadership roles such as Chief Commercial Officer.

SUITABILITY SIGNALS:

Business development careers are well suited to individuals who are motivated by deal-making and achieving growth targets. Those who enjoy building long-term commercial relationships and influencing business outcomes tend to find the work rewarding. People who are comfortable with uncertainty and can handle rejection without losing motivation are more likely to succeed. An interest in understanding markets, customers, and competitive dynamics is also important. Individuals who combine strong interpersonal skills with strategic thinking are particularly well matched to this field.

CAREER PROGRESSION:

Career progression in business development often begins with entry-level roles such as business development executive or sales associate. With experience, individuals can move into roles such as partnership manager, market expansion manager, or sales strategist. Senior professionals may progress to leadership positions such as head of growth, commercial director, or BD director, where they oversee entire growth strategies. Business development experience is highly transferable and can lead to general management roles, as it provides a deep understanding of revenue generation and market dynamics. Many professionals also transition into entrepreneurship, using their skills to build and scale their own businesses.

MARKET OUTLOOK (MALAYSIA, 2024-2030):

The demand for business development professionals in Malaysia is expected to remain strong between 2024 and 2030, driven by the growth of the digital economy and increasing regional integration within Southeast Asia. Companies are expanding into new markets and seeking partnerships to stay competitive, creating more opportunities for skilled professionals. Roles that combine business development with digital knowledge, such as e-commerce or SaaS, are particularly in demand. Entry-level salaries typically range from RM3,000 to RM5,000 per month, while experienced professionals can earn between RM6,000 and RM15,000 or more, often with performance-based incentives. Senior leadership roles can command significantly higher compensation depending on the organisation and industry.

RELATED INDUSTRIES:

Sales is closely related to business development, as both focus on revenue generation and customer acquisition, although business development is often more strategic in nature.

Consulting is another related industry, as it involves advising organisations on growth strategies, market entry, and partnerships. Digital media is also increasingly connected, especially as companies use online platforms to drive growth and reach new audiences. These industries offer alternative or complementary career paths for individuals with business development skills.